

- RAG Learning

3A.5 US Democracy and Participation

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 3A: Comparative Politics — USA

Exam Tip: Component 3 has two routes. This is **3A (USA)**; the alternative is **3B (Global Politics)**. You sit one, never both.

This topic covers how Americans choose their government and how organised interests influence it. The recurring theme is that the **rules** — the Electoral College, primaries, single-member districts, campaign finance law — shape outcomes at least as much as opinion does.

Electoral College — the body of 538 electors that formally elects the President; 270 needed to win.

Primary — a state-run election selecting a party's candidate; closed (party members only) or open.

Caucus — a party-run meeting where participants deliberate and declare a preference publicly.

Invisible primary — the period before voting, spent building funds, endorsements and name recognition.

Swing state — a state whose result is genuinely uncertain, and where campaigns concentrate.

PAC — raises and spends money for candidates, subject to contribution limits.

Super PAC — may raise and spend unlimited sums, but may not coordinate with a campaign.

Soft money — donations to parties for general party-building, outside FECA contribution limits; banned for national parties by BCRA 2002.

Dark money — political spending by organisations (e.g. 501(c)(4) groups) not required to disclose their donors.

Iron triangle — a stable alliance of congressional committee, federal agency and interest group.

Split-ticket voting — supporting different parties for different offices on the same ballot.

1. Presidential elections

The Electoral College

Each state has electors equal to its congressional representation — two senators plus its House members. DC has three. 538 total; **270** to win. All states except Maine and Nebraska allocate on a **winner-takes-all** basis. If no candidate reaches 270 the House elects the President, voting by state delegation — one vote per state.

Criticisms	Defences
Can elect the popular-vote loser — 2000 and 2016	Preserves federalism: the President is elected by the states as constituent units
Winner-takes-all means safe states are ignored; campaigning concentrates on a handful of swing states	Obliges candidates to build geographically broad coalitions rather than run up margins in population centres
Small states are overrepresented, so votes are weighted unequally	Converts a narrow national margin into a decisive result, avoiding nationwide recounts
"Faithless electors" are possible, though rare and now restricted in many states	Reform is effectively impossible — the states advantaged by it can block an amendment

Nomination: primaries and caucuses

Before the reforms of the early 1970s, nominees were chosen largely by party figures at conventions. Primaries transferred that power to voters — which democratised selection and **weakened the parties as institutions**.

- **The invisible primary** now begins years ahead; fundraising and endorsements screen the field before any vote is cast.
- **Front-loading** — states moved their contests earlier to gain influence, compressing the effective decision into a few weeks.
- **Turnout is low and participants are more ideologically committed**, so candidates position towards the base rather than the centre.

- **Consequence:** because the party organisation no longer controls selection, an insurgent can capture a major party rather than found a new one — which is a far more efficient route to power than third-party formation, and helps explain why third parties fail.

National party conventions

Held in the summer of election year, conventions formally confirm the nominee and the running mate, adopt the party platform, and launch the general election campaign — often producing a short-lived poll “bounce”. Since primaries now decide the nominee in advance, they have lost their decision-making role and are largely media events designed to unite the party. They regain significance only when the result is open: in 2024 the Democrats' virtual roll call confirmed Harris after Biden withdrew in July.

Incumbency

Incumbent Presidents enjoy name recognition, the bully pulpit, control of events, fundraising strength and usually no serious primary challenge, and most who seek re-election win. But incumbency is no guarantee: Carter (1980), Bush (1992) and Trump (2020) all lost re-election bids (Trump returning in 2024 for a non-consecutive second term), and Biden withdrew from the 2024 race. In Congress the advantage is far stronger — House incumbents are re-elected at rates usually above 90%.

2. Campaign finance

Development	Effect
FECA 1971 / 1974	Disclosure, contribution limits, public funding for presidential campaigns
<i>Buckley v Valeo</i> (1976)	Spending is speech: limits on <i>expenditure</i> unconstitutional, limits on <i>contributions</i> permitted
BCRA 2002	Restricted soft money to national parties; regulated issue advertising near elections

Citizens United (2010)	Independent political spending by corporations and unions is protected speech
Super PACs	Unlimited raising and spending, provided there is no coordination — a restriction widely regarded as weakly enforced

The strongest argument that money corrupts is not that it buys votes but that it **screens candidates before voters see them**: the fundraising a viable campaign requires determines who can run at all. Against that: spending often follows viability rather than creating it, heavily outspent candidates sometimes win, and restricting political spending raises genuine First Amendment objections. Because the Court treats spending as speech, most reform requires a change in the Court's composition or a constitutional amendment.

3. The two parties

	Democrats	Republicans
Broad position	Government action on healthcare, welfare, environment; socially liberal	Lower taxation, deregulation, strong defence; socially conservative
Coalition	Urban, minority ethnic, graduate, younger voters	Rural and small-town, white evangelical, non-graduate, older voters
Internal factions	Progressive and moderate wings	Fiscal conservatives, social conservatives, populists, libertarians

Polarisation and realignment

The parties once overlapped ideologically — conservative southern Democrats and liberal northeastern Republicans supplied the cross-party majorities the system's supermajority requirements demand. Realignment, accelerated by the civil rights legislation of the 1960s and the subsequent southern shift, sorted them into distinct camps. Primaries, safe districts, geographic sorting and partisan media now reward positioning towards the base. The result is less legislation, oversight that tracks party control, and confirmation battles decided by raw majority power.

Why third parties fail

- Single-member plurality districts and winner-takes-all Electoral College allocation convert dispersed support into no offices — Ross Perot won 18.9% in 1992 and no electoral votes.
- Ballot access requirements vary by state and impose real costs.
- Major parties co-opt successful third-party positions.
- Primaries provide an internal route: capture a party rather than found one.
- Wasted-vote perceptions depress support below its true level.

4. Interest groups

Method	Detail
Lobbying	Direct representation to members, staff and agencies; supplying expertise and drafted text
Electioneering	Endorsements, ratings, PAC and Super PAC spending, mobilising members
Litigation	A codified constitution with entrenched rights makes the courts a route to policy change — the NAACP's strategy culminating in <i>Brown</i> is the model
Grassroots mobilisation	Organising members to contact representatives; demonstrations
Iron triangles	Committee, agency and group with aligned interests, insulating a policy area from wider scrutiny

Pluralism against elitism

Pluralist case: an extraordinary density of groups, and the separation of powers plus federalism creates many access points — Congress, agencies, the courts, the states — so no single interest controls any field. On Madison's argument in Federalist 10, the multiplicity of factions prevents any one dominating.

Elitist case: access follows resources, so corporate and professional interests achieve insider status far more readily than diffuse public ones. Iron triangles insulate whole policy areas. Empirical work finds policy tracks the preferences of affluent Americans and organised business far more closely than those of the median voter.

Judgement: the competition pluralists describe genuinely occurs, on a field so unevenly weighted that the outcomes elitists predict follow anyway. The number of groups is the wrong measure — what matters is *whose* interests are organised, and diffuse public interests face collective action problems that concentrated producer interests do not. Madison's remedy therefore fails on its own terms.

Exam Tip: For a comparative question on pressure groups, the structural explanation is the one that earns marks: US groups have more access points because federalism and the separation of powers create them, and litigation is effective because a codified constitution gives courts something to enforce. UK groups must generally work on the government, because parliamentary sovereignty closes the judicial route.

Quick recall

- 538 electors, 270 to win; winner-takes-all except Maine and Nebraska; popular-vote loser won in 2000 and 2016
- Primaries transferred selection from party leaders to voters — democratising and party-weakening at once
- *Buckley* 1976 (spending is speech), BCRA 2002, *Citizens United* 2010, Super PACs
- Money screens candidates before voters see them — the strongest corruption argument
- Perot 1992: 18.9% and zero electoral votes
- Interest group methods: lobbying, electioneering, litigation, grassroots, iron triangles
- Pluralism describes the competition; elitism describes the outcomes — both are accurate about different things